FORGE Handbook

Facilitating Opportunities for Reentry, Growth & Empowerment

FORGE's mission is to build mentors who lead by example, create conflict-free dorms, and live out the principle of *Service Over Self* — helping others grow, strengthening our communities, and turning time served into time that serves others.

Leadership begins when we stop living only for ourselves and start building others.

Elevator Speech (You need to memorize this.)

FORGE — Facilitating Opportunities for Reentry, Growth & Empowerment

We're building a new prison experience — where men lead by example, support one another, and prepare to make a positive impact — both inside these walls and beyond them.

Our goal is simple: to **turn time served into time that serves others.**

Our Purpose:

To build mentors who create a culture of peace, responsibility, and service — modeling the change we want to see in every community.

You Are a Stakeholder

In the last several years, violence inside Georgia's prisons has sky-rocketed. Not just murders, but stabbings and fights, many of which are never even reported. Things must change. We all want to go home one day. This includes staff and inmates alike.

Many of us have come to see that we must take on some of the responsibility to build our own rehabilitation system and create a safer environment to live in. That's what FORGE is about.

A **stakeholder** is someone who has something at stake — something to gain or lose based on what happens around them. You are a stakeholder in this system. The conditions you live in are shaped by peer behavior: how conflicts are handled, how pressure is applied, and whether violence is encouraged or discouraged.

FORGE channels that reality into something constructive. Instead of peer influence being used to intimidate or control, FORGE trains men to use their influence to **reduce harm, resolve conflict, and build others up**. That's what a stakeholder does — they take ownership of the environment they share with everyone else.

Being a stakeholder in FORGE means accepting that your actions affect not only yourself, but everyone living around you — including staff. It means choosing restraint over reaction, accountability over avoidance, and stability over chaos. It means understanding that you are not just going through a program. **You are part of the solution.**

What That Looks Like

- When you see conflict building, you step in early — before it becomes violence.
- When someone is struggling, you offer support instead of looking the other way.
- When you make a mistake, you own it — because accountability builds trust.
- When the dorm standards slip, you hold the line — because this is your community.

The stakeholder model does not replace staff authority. It complements it. FORGE creates a peer culture that supports order rather than undermines it. A dorm where trained mentors are actively building peace is a dorm that is safer for everyone — inmates and staff alike.

You have more power to change this environment than you realize.
FORGE gives you the skills to use that power responsibly.

The FORGE Curriculum

FORGE is a **36-week, 108-session training program** that meets three times per week for two hours each session. The curriculum is organized into three phases, and each phase must be completed before moving to the next.

Phase 1: Foundation — "Know Yourself" (Weeks 1–12)

This phase is about doing your own work first. Before you can help anyone else, you have to understand yourself. You'll learn to identify your thinking errors, manage your emotions, communicate without escalation, resolve conflict through the FORGE 5-step model, take full accountability for your choices, and develop a growth mindset.

Phase 2: Development — "Build Others" (Weeks 13–24)

Now you learn to help others grow. Phase 2 trains you in teaching and facilitation, motivational interviewing, simulation-based training with realistic dorm scenarios, and restorative justice practices. You'll practice leading sessions and handling difficult situations before you face them for real.

Phase 3: Practicum — "Lead and Serve" (Weeks 25–36)

Training becomes reality. You work under supervision as a mentor, co-leading sessions with the next incoming cohort, handling real conflicts, and building toward certification. By the end, you'll have completed 60 hours of supervised mentoring and be evaluated by a review board of your peers and staff.

What's Expected of You

- **Attendance:** At least 85% of sessions — no more than 5 absences per phase.
- **Participation:** Show up ready to learn, practice, and contribute. Every session counts.
- **Portfolio:** Written exercises, reflections, and assessments that document your growth.
- **Conduct:** The Code of Conduct applies at all times — in class, in the dorm, everywhere.
- **Peer accountability:** Your cohort members will evaluate you at each gate. Your reputation matters.

The curriculum is built from programs proven to work in prisons across the country — programs that have reduced violence, lowered recidivism, and helped men build lives they can be proud of. This is real training, grounded in real evidence. It won't be easy. But nothing worth having ever is.

This is your opportunity. What you do with it is up to you.

Leadership Through Service

In FORGE, leadership begins with service. A true leader practices *Service Over Self* — putting the needs of others and the community before personal convenience, comfort, or recognition.

Leadership in FORGE is not about power or position; it's about responsibility. It's the choice to act in ways that make the dorm safer, the men stronger, and the community better.

Principles of Leadership Through Service

1. **Be the Example**
People follow what they see more than what they hear. Keep your space clean, your word honest, and your actions consistent. Every time you choose respect over reaction, you teach others how to lead.

2. **Serve First**
Ask yourself daily, *"Who can I help today?"* Help someone study, settle a conflict, or lift their mindset. A small act of service creates a ripple that strengthens the entire dorm.

3. **Protect the Culture**
Step in early when you see disrespect, gossip, or potential conflict. Leadership means guarding the peace and setting the tone for everyone around you.

4. **Reject Weapons and Violence**
Weapons will never be tolerated in a FORGE dorm. They destroy trust, safety, and everything this program stands for. Anyone found with a weapon will be removed from the program immediately. True strength is shown through control — not intimidation.

5. **Teach What You Know**
Mentors share what they've learned — not to boast, but to build. When you teach, you grow. When you help another man grow, you lead.

Real leaders don't rise above others — they lift others with them.

Service Over Self is the foundation of peace, trust, and transformation.

Attitude & Mindset: The Foundation of Reentry

Reentry doesn't start with a gate — it starts in the mind. A man's attitude shapes every outcome: his choices, his peace, and his future. In FORGE, we teach that how you think determines how you live.

The Power of Attitude

- **Attitude is everything.**
  It's the difference between reacting and responding, between giving up and growing. A positive attitude can turn a bad day into a lesson, and a setback into a step forward.
- **"Your attitude, not your aptitude, will determine your altitude."** — *Zig Ziglar*
  You don't have to control everything around you — only your response to it.
- **Choose gratitude over bitterness.**
  Gratitude builds strength. When you focus on what you can control and appreciate, you create peace that no one can take away.
- **Stay solution-minded.**
  Don't ask, *"Why me?"* — ask, *"What can I learn from this?"* Leaders and mentors don't look for excuses — they look for opportunities.

Building a Winning Mindset

1. **Focus on Growth**
Growth is a daily decision. Read, reflect, and learn something new each day. Progress doesn't happen all at once — it happens one small victory at a time.

2. **Take Ownership**
Freedom begins with responsibility. Own your actions, your words, and your energy. No one can change your life for you — but others will follow your example when you lead yourself.

3. **Live on Purpose**
Every day in FORGE has a purpose: to learn, to serve, to grow. Use your time to make yourself and your dorm stronger. When your life has purpose, every minute counts.

4. **Think Forward**
Picture the man you want to be — disciplined, calm, respected. Ask daily, *"Am I acting like that man today?"*
What you rehearse in here becomes who you are out there.

A positive attitude turns obstacles into lessons and pain into progress.
Change your attitude — change your life.
Reentry starts long before release; it begins when you start thinking free.

Leadership begins when we stop living only for ourselves and start building others.

Conflict Resolution

Goal: Lower heat quickly, solve the real problem, and leave everyone's dignity intact.

Steps to Resolve Conflict

1. **Pause & Posture**
Shoulders down, hands visible, voice calm. Take two full 4-in/4-out breaths before responding.

2. **Name the Heat**
Say what you see: "I can tell you're frustrated. I want to understand."

3. **Facts > Stories**
Each person shares what happened — no insults, no past cases, no blame. Keep it to 60 seconds each.

4. **Needs & Options**
Identify the real need (respect, safety, fairness, property). Brainstorm 2–3 workable options that meet those needs.

5. **Agreement & Check-Back**
Confirm who will do what, and by when. "We'll check in tomorrow to make sure this stuck."

Red Lines

- No threats.
- No weapons talk.
- No gang language or authorization claims.

Weapons will not be tolerated.
Anyone found with a weapon will be immediately removed from the FORGE program.

Quick Scripts

- "I'm here to help you win, not to win against you."
- "Let's cool for ten. I'll find you at the tables."
- "I'll listen to you fully; please give the same back."

The goal isn't to win the argument — it's to protect the peace.

Dorm Standards & Rules

The dorm is our shared environment — a space built on respect, safety, and accountability. Every person's actions affect everyone else. When we protect this space, we protect each other.

Respect

- Speak to others with calmness and dignity.
- No shouting, slurs, gossip, or threats.
- Remember: your attitude sets the tone for the dorm.

Clean & Quiet

- Keep your area and shared spaces clean and organized.
- Honor quiet hours. Be respectful of those who are studying, sleeping, or reflecting.
- Keep TVs, music, and conversations at a reasonable volume, especially after 10 p.m.

Property

- Ask before touching or borrowing anything that isn't yours.
- Respect both personal property and shared resources.
- Taking or damaging someone else's property breaks trust and will not be tolerated.

Weapons & Safety

- **Weapons are not tolerated in FORGE dorms.**
- Any person caught with a weapon of any kind will be removed from the program.
- Violence and intimidation have no place here. True strength is shown through restraint, respect, and leadership.

Mediation First

- When conflict arises, bring it to a mentor before it becomes harm.
- We solve problems with communication — not confrontation.
- If a disagreement starts to escalate, take a step back, breathe, and ask for help.

Class & Program Requirements

- Attend every class or meeting you are scheduled for.
- Be on time. (No sign-ins after five minutes.)
- Stay engaged — every class is an opportunity to grow.
- Leave the classroom clean and ready for the next group.

Peace is built by discipline.

Respect is built by consistency.

Safety is built by trust.

FORGE Code of Conduct

The **FORGE Code of Conduct** defines the standard of behavior expected from every participant and mentor. It's built on respect, responsibility, and growth. Each action in the dorm either strengthens or weakens the community — every choice matters.

1. Integrity & Accountability

- Always do the right thing, even when no one is watching.
- Keep your word — reliability builds trust.
- Admit mistakes quickly, make them right, and move forward.
- Never deceive, manipulate, or take advantage of others.
- Integrity means doing what's right, not what's easy.

Accountability is the foundation of leadership.

2. Leadership & Service

- Lead through service, not control.
- Offer help before being asked. Cooperation strengthens the community.
- Recognize the value in every person, regardless of background or status.
- Be the example others can follow — your attitude sets the tone.
- Share knowledge freely and lift others up.

Leadership is service in motion.

3. Learning & Growth

- Approach challenges as opportunities, not obstacles.
- Accept feedback with humility; use it to improve.
- Replace complaints with solutions — negativity stops progress.
- Stay engaged in personal growth, education, and self-discipline.
- Encourage others to pursue learning and celebrate their progress.

Growth begins the moment we stop making excuses.

4. Peace & Safety

- Violence, threats, bullying, and intimidation have no place in FORGE.
- De-escalate tension through communication, not confrontation.
- **Weapons will not be tolerated.** Anyone caught with a weapon will be removed from the program.
- No gang language, symbols, or signals inside the dorm.
- Protect each other's safety and peace of mind — everyone deserves to feel secure.

Peace is the strength to stay calm when others can't.

5. Community & Conduct

- Participate in dorm activities, meetings, and chores — community takes effort.
- Speak to staff and peers with professionalism and respect.
- Protect the dorm's reputation by maintaining order and cleanliness.
- Never exploit others in any form.
- Use every privilege and resource responsibly.

Strong communities are built by men who show up and serve.

6. Mindset & Mission

- Every day is an opportunity to practice freedom, discipline, and change.
- Live today like the man you want to be tomorrow.
- Forgive quickly — grudges poison growth.
- Keep living the principles of FORGE: **Opportunity, Growth, Empowerment.**
- Remember that your transformation will inspire others long after you're gone.

Your mission is bigger than yourself — live it daily.

Participant Commitment & Signature

By joining FORGE, I accept both the privilege and the responsibility of being part of a brotherhood built on discipline, peace, and service. I understand that my actions, words, and attitude directly shape the safety, growth, and success of this dorm.

I commit to:

- Lead by example in every circumstance.
- Respect every person as I wish to be respected.
- Keep this dorm safe — free from weapons, violence, and fear.
- Practice *Service Over Self* by helping others grow.
- Live by the principles of **Opportunity, Growth, and Empowerment.**

I understand that being part of FORGE is more than a program — it's a way of life. My commitment is to live with integrity, serve with humility, and mentor with purpose.

I will turn time served into time that serves others.

Acknowledgment

Participant Name: _____

Signature: _____**Date:** _____

Mentor / Witness Name: _____

Signature: _____**Date:** _____

The FORGE Way

FORGE is more than a name — it's a process. Just as metal is refined by fire, character is shaped by struggle, and purpose is strengthened by service. Every act of patience, every moment of restraint, and every choice to help someone else builds who you are becoming.

Leadership is not granted — it's forged. And in that process, we discover that service isn't sacrifice — it's freedom.

Leadership begins when we stop living only for ourselves and start building others.